

Appendix A



State of Practice of {domain} Software

Oral Consent Script (Start of Meeting)

Introduction:

Hello. I'm {Student Investigator}. I am the Student Principal Investigator conducting interviews about the state of practice of {domain} software. I'm conducting this as part of research for my studies at McMaster University's Department of Computing and Software in Hamilton, Ontario, Canada. I'm working under the direction Dr. Smith of McMaster's Department of Engineering.

<[In the case where Christopher would like to ask Ziyang to join for training purposes.] If you are agreeable, I would like to ask my colleague Ziyang Fang, another Student Investigator, to join us. Ziyang is new to interview techniques and would benefit from observing. With your consent, I will ask Ziyang to join us. If you prefer, we can proceed without Ziyang. [Pause to invite Ziyang to the call, if oral consent has been granted.]>

I located your name/email by visiting the website of {research software name}.

Study procedures:

This one-on-one teleconference interview that will take about 60 minutes. I will ask you questions about {research software name} such as obstacles you encountered while developing the software, and about the development process. The audio answers to your questions will be temporarily recorded and securely saved on Microsoft Teams. The data will be retained for 3 years after the study and then deleted.

Risks:

The risks have been described in the letter of consent that you received. To review, there are no physical risks, there is little psychological risk. You may feel that your work is being scrutinized. We assure that our questions are objective and technical, and do not suggest a course of action. The social risk associated with this interview is minimal. We will keep your identity private. However, maintaining the privacy of interviewed sole developers, or members from a small developer team, may not be possible since their identities can potentially be inferred. The interviewee will have to accept this risk if they choose to be interviewed. All personal information will be stored securely on password protected email accounts on password protected computers. You do not need to answer questions that make you feel uncomfortable or that you do not want to answer, and you can withdraw at any time. After the interview all that would be required to withdraw your answers would be an e-mail to me or the principle investigator (Dr. Smith). You can withdraw up until we analyze all data of this research project on August 8th, 2026.

Information that could identify you will not be published or shared beyond the research team unless we have your permission.

Benefits:

The answers to these interview questions will help us analyze the current state of practice of software development, and provide insight into common or best practices for the benefit of future software development. However, participants may not benefit from participating in the study.

Voluntary participation:

- Your participation in this study is voluntary.
- You can decide to stop at any time, even part-way through the interview for whatever reason, or up until approximately August 30th, 2026
- If you decide to stop participating, there will be no consequences to you.
- If you decide to stop we will ask you how you would like us to handle the data collected up to that point.
- This could include returning it to you, destroying it or using the data collected up to that point.
- If you do not want to answer some of the questions you do not have to, but you can still be in the study.
- If you have any questions about this study or would like more information you can call or email Dr. Smith, at 1-905-525-9140 X27929 or smiths@mcmaster.ca

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This study has been reviewed by the McMaster Research Ethics Board and received ethics clearance under project 8215. If you have concerns or questions about your rights as a participant or about the way the study is conducted, please contact McMaster Research Ethics Office by phone: (905) 525-9140 ext. 23142 or e-mail: mreb@mcmaster.ca.

I would be pleased to send you the study results when they are complete. Please let me know if you would like a summary and what would be the best way to get this to you.

Consent questions:

- Do you have any questions or would like any additional details? *[Answer questions.]*
- Do you agree to participate in this study knowing that you can withdraw at any point with no consequences to you?
 - *[If no, thank the participant for his/her time.]*
- Do you agree that that interview can be audio recorded?
- Would you like a copy of the study results?

- *[If yes, ask where the results are to be sent.]*

[begin the interview]